Deaf Ears and Echo Chambers in Presidential News

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Abstract

Numerous studies argue public opinion checks presidential power, especially unilateral action. In his second term, President Trump has pursued a maximalist strategy, issuing more executive actions than any modern president — many facing majority or supermajority opposition in polls. Yet no significant backlash has emerged. We argue the disconnect stems, in part, from how the contemporary public learns about the presidency. Using web-tracking data containing 13.2 million site visits linked to a Fall 2025 survey of 1,000 respondents, we show that (a) the public almost never reads about executive action online, and (b) when they do read about President Trump, conservative (liberal) respondents are more likely to consume (un)favorable news stories. We also show that, within-party, differences in views toward a strong executive further moderate consumption of presidential news. These findings help reconcile the theory of the public check with the ostensible lack of evidence for it in contemporary politics.

Keywords: American politics, presidency, public opinion, media, echo chambers

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Scholars have long argued the American presidency, and in particular, its capacity for unilateral power, can undermine the separation of powers and the stability of democratic governance.[1] A recent swell of studies argue that public opinion checks that power because presidents fear backlash (e.g., Christenson and Kriner 2015, 2017, 2019, 2020; Reeves and Rogowski 2015, 2018, 2022, 2023). If true, then fears about presidential unilateral power may be overblown.

But these arguments stand in apparent contrast to several stylized facts about the second Trump administration. First, President Trump has undertaken many policy initiatives on his own, launching more unilateral initiatives than any modern president in his first term of office (e.g., Pew Research Center 2025b; Rattner 2025). Second, those initiatives are themselves widely unpopular (Morris 2026; Pew Research Center 2026). Yet, his approval ratings have been slow to decline, and are statistically indistinguishable from both his first term and President Biden—neither of which saw a strategy of issuing hundreds of unpopular executive actions (Gallup 2025; Pew Research Center 2025a). Moreover, this case is not isolated or exceptional. Outside of surveys, it is difficult to find even circumstantial evidence that the public responds directly to the behavior of presidents (Edwards 2003), let alone evidence of the public sanctioning of presidents for issuing particular unilateral directives.

We reconcile the disconnect by applying two properties of information consumption in contemporary politics: namely, the general inattention of the public, and differential partisan consumption of news content (e.g., Broockman and Kalla 2025; Heseltine, Barnehl, and Wojcieszak 2025). The former ensures information take-up will be glacial, whereas the latter suggests that it will be biased. Both of these are known phenomena, but evidence they exist and are relevant for the accountability of particular political institutions is missing. We argue that in the case of the presidency, these features undermine the public check on presidential power and help reconcile the empirical patterns that otherwise imply it should operate.

We leverage individual-level web-tracking data, paired with an online survey of Americans. These data contain roughly 13.2 million website visits over a 6-week period in the Fall of 2025. Despite a near constant pace of executive actions issued by the Trump administration, we find just over 3,000 total instances of news visits related to executive action, confined to approximately one-third of our respondents. This implies that over a period of this kind, the likelihood of a respondent clicking through to information about executive action online is 0.02%.

This, however, does not mean respondents did not read about stories related to the president. We

1. For a recent review of this area of research, see Lowande and Rogowski (2021).

show that though web-traffic related to the president is less frequent than visits to walmart.com, important news stories that may be relevant for the president's approval—like the so-called "Epstein files" and the November special elections—do receive significant attention from respondents. In total, respondents clicked on just over 54,000 sites relevant to President Trump or his administration.

Nonetheless, consistent with other work, we find partisan variation in who is consuming this information. In particular, we show that stories that paint Trump in a more positive light are more likely to be consumed by Republicans and conservatives, than Democrats and liberals. The inverse is true when the news is bad for Trump, with opponents of the president being more likely to click on relevant stories. Finally, we also demonstrate that these differences in consumption pattern are in part moderated by within-party variation in views toward presidential power (a la Reeves and Rogowski 2022). Democrats who are especially loath of executive power are even more likely to be consuming information about Trump compared to their co-partisan peers who are more supportive of presidents acting on their own.

Our evidence has important implications for the study of presidents and their relationship with the public, namely, by clarifying the context in which the public check on executive power might operate. Individual actions, seemingly regardless of their importance, are unlikely to meaningfully change perceptions of the president, because respondents simply do not know about them, and what they do learn is downstream of existing biases. This implies that presidents' decisions around *individual* executive actions are largely free of the threat of public sanction. What remains to be investigated is whether more impressionistic, or heuristic-based accountability models (e.g., Lupia and McCubbins 1998) might still function.

Political Knowledge, News Consumption, and Echo Chambers

Information is a key tenet of democracy and a requisite for checking presidential power. While some work finds that the American electorate is vastly uninformed in political matters (Bartels 2003; Converse 2006), other work suggests that the electorate effectively uses heuristics to make well-informed decisions (Lupia 1994; Lupia and McCubbins 1998). Regardless of one's evaluation of the electorate, the public is generally under-informed about politics (Carpini and Keeter 1996), and the implications of being politically informed are consequential. Politically sophisticated citizens participate more in politics, are more stable in their political attitudes, can link their own interests with political attitudes, and support democratic norms (Delli Carpini 2000). However, in order for the public to become more knowledgeable, there needs to be an adequate supply of information that people can consume in a digestible manner.

News media provides abundant, diverse information sources for the public to learn from. The large supply of news sources puts the onus on the public to maintain a healthy media diet.

Web-tracking, cable-tracking, and self-report survey data all help demonstrate whether the public utilizes the news media to learn more about politics (e.g., Dubois and Blank 2018; Gentzkow and Shapiro 2011; Prior 2009). In the 1960s, they were. Back then, television news helped educate and increase turnout among the politically inattentive, largely because viewers had very few alternatives available to them (Prior 2005, 2007). Things changed in the 1980s with the rise of entertainment media. Once people were given this new option, less interested people replaced their news consumption with this new medium (Prior 2005, 2007). Today, people seldom seek political news (Konitzer et al. 2021; Menchen-Trevino et al. 2023), and those who do tend to be partisan and ideological (Prior 2013); this differential is consequently responsible for widening the turnout and knowledge gap in the electorate (Prior 2005, 2007; Wolfsfeld, Yarchi, and Samuel-Azran 2016). Not only are political sophisticates consuming news at disproportionate rates, they are also known to develop media habits (LaRose 2010).

An echo chamber can be defined as a "bounded, enclosed media spaces that has potential to both magnify the messages delivered within it and insulate them from rebuttal" (Jamieson and Cappella 2008, 76). A worry associated with echo chambers is their ability to fuel affective polarization (Prior 2013), resulting in deleterious individual- and societal-level consequences. For instance, research suggests that exposing partisans to attitudinally congruent information can strengthen their priors (Levendusky 2013b), increase anger toward out-partisans (Hasell and Weeks 2016), and diminish support for bipartisanship (Levendusky 2013a). However, much of this worry is ameliorated if people do not find themselves in echo chambers to begin with. The research on echo chambers is mixed, with some research finding support for selective partisan exposure among the most politically engaged (e.g., Muise et al. 2022; Iyengar and Hahn 2009; Tyler, Grimmer, and Iyengar 2022), while other research suggests the fear of echo chambers may be overstated since there is still some degree of cross-cutting exposure (e.g., Garrett 2009; Gentzkow and Shapiro 2011; Guess 2021).

Notably, none of this research speaks directly to patterns that would be relevant for the public check on presidential power. Accordingly, our analyses examine the public's consumption of information to reconcile empirical irregularities we see with respect to presidential approval and unilateral action.

Evidence

We acquired url-level data on the webpages visited by 995 survey respondents over a two-month period from September 24, 2025 to November 23, 2025.[2] These data were obtained through YouGov Safe, a web application users install and receive compensation for linking their account-based web history. It provides a granular window into Americans' online activity, with over 13,295,187 pages visited by respondents during our study window. Data contain name of the website, the page's html `<title>` tag, the date and time the respondent clicked on the webpage, and a thematic categorization of the website created by YouGov.[3] While the browser data are anonymous, they are linked to a survey of respondents' views toward presidential power (which we discuss in greater detail below) and basic demographic, economic, and political data on participants.

Respondents opt into Yougov Safe and upload their own online data periodically. After agreeing to participate, respondents install a Chrome browser extension and decide which specific types of data to share with YouGov, such as streaming, shopping, or Chrome browser activity. Even after installing the extension plug-in, YouGov does not automatically collect respondents' browser data. They are not required to upload data and can decide to change which types of data they provide at any time.

This feature of the data collection raises questions about bias in the types of online activity uploaded. There is some evidence of censoring in the sample. For example, 28% of men and 8% of women visited at least one pornographic website, such as `pornhub.com` or `onlyfans.com` during the two-month study period. This is lower than rates in nationally representative, anonymous surveys on the topic, which suggest the figures for a two-month period are closer to 47% of men and 16% of women (Grubbs, Kraus, and Perry 2019). This kind of censoring would pose a problem if our outcome was illicit or sensitive, but presidential news—over the study period, at least—was not. Moreover, the exclusion of online pornography, along with other self-censored and sensitive behavior, is likely to *inflate* the prevalence of respondents' news consumption, relative to their other browsing. This means that the dearth of news consumption we show next is, if anything, an overstatement.

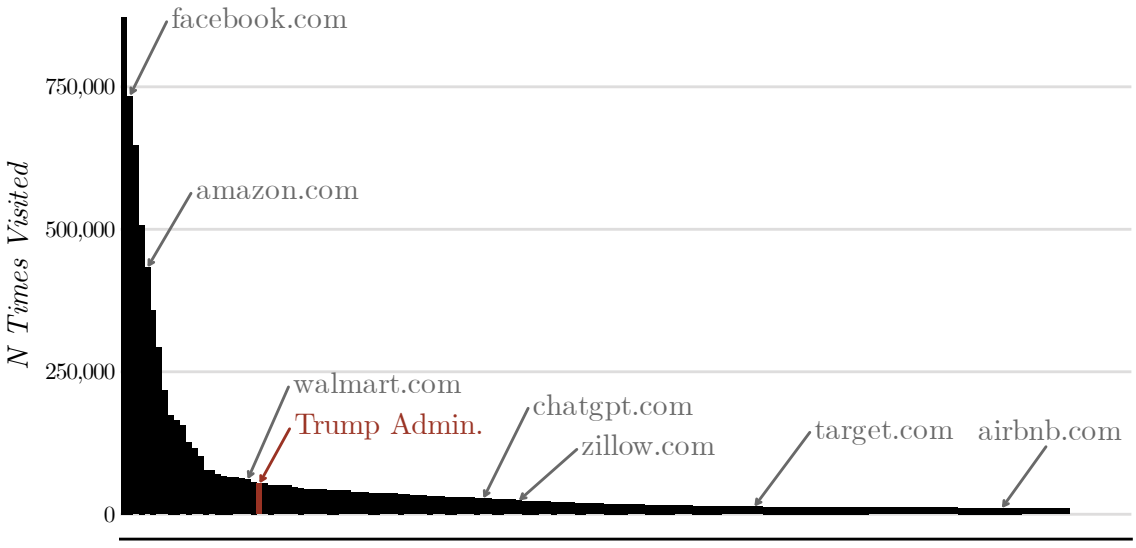
Most online activity is apolitical and unrelated to the news. Figure 1 shows the number of visits to the 161 most-visited websites in our data, relative to the total number of visits, across all webpages, to sites about President Trump and his administration. We define a site to concern the Trump admin-

2. Five participants in the 1,000 person survey did not upload any browser data.

3. An example of a website is the Wall Street Journal's wsj.com. An example of a webpage is a site on wsj.com, such as this story on flying cars: https://www.wsj.com/lifestyle/cars/i-test-drove-a-flying-car-get-ready-theyre-here-257b0ecfst=aop6my&reflink=desktopwebshare_permalink&utm_source=substack&utm_medium=email

istration if the page's html `<title>` tag contains the string "trump", "maga", "rfk", "noem", "vance", "hegseth", or "patel". Traffic to sites containing information about the Trump administration exceeded the number of visits to many well-known sites, such as `chatgpt.com`, `zillow.com`, `target.com`, and `airbnb.com`. Other, more popular sites, however, such as `amazon.com` and `facebook.com` receive considerably more traffic than Trump-related webpages. Total visits to Trump-related sites is largely on par with the number of visits to `walmart.com`.

Figure 1 – More People Visit Walmart.com Than Visit all Webpages Concerning the Trump Administration. Shows the number of visits by website during the two-month study period relative to the number of all visited webpages containing the string "trump", "maga", "rfk", "noem", "vance", "hegseth", or "patel". For readability, the plot only shows the 161 websites with the most visits. This is 0.001% of all unique websites in the dataset.



Much of this information, however, consists of general stories about the president rather than specific unilateral actions. We determine whether a webpage is focused on covering unilateral actions taken by President Trump by searching the page's html `<title>` tag for various terms suggesting the president is acting alone.[4] Because we do not examine the full text of these webpages, there will be some false positives. Likewise, we will miss some webpages that mention executive action, but not prominently enough to reference it in the title. We have no reason to expect these errors will be systematically under-report or over-report executive action, or that those pages will be visited by particular respondents.

Of the 43,785 webpages with "trump" in the `title` tag, only 3,079 (7%) contain action-oriented

4. In particular, we deem a page to concern a unilateral action if it contains "trump" and one of the following words: "direct", "demand", "declare", "require", "order", "memo", "mandate", "decree", "proclaim", "proclamation", "directive", "fiat", "edict", "enjoin", "invoke", "invoking", "bypass", "circumvent", "override", "overrule", "suspend", "waive", "nullify", "revoke", "rescind", "impose", "instruct", "compel", "enforce", "authorize", "designate", "withdraw", "halt", "freeze", or "unilateral".

words. This is about 0.02% of the web traffic over this period. It is worth dwelling on how small this figure is, relative to the steady stream of important news about presidential power over the study period. Our period featured ongoing conflicts over strikes on boats off in the Caribbean, and new tariffs on China and heavy duty trucks—both of which, drew some bipartisan legislative action in opposition. It also included a troop deployment in Chicago, and an executive order that subjected all future high-level, career civil servants to a political hiring committee. In other words, there were numerous actions scholars would deem "significant." Their collective imprint on the daily life of the typical web user is a rounding error.

These top line figures, of course, can only tell us so much. It might be that a single news story carries much weight, especially over such a short period of time. Thus, we next test for partisan differences in online news consumption by comparing webpage visits in the days immediately before and after an event. If differential consumption occurs, then the net effect of the admittedly minuscule consumption would be even further muted.

We expect news-seeking to be associated with whether the news has positive or negative implications for the president. This means we must define some set of "positive" and "negative" stories for President Trump. Over our time window, we examine two favorable events for Trump: the onset of a ceasefire in the Gaza Strip on October 9th and the end of the government shutdown on November 12th. In one poll, 68% of voters stated that Trump should get some or a great deal of credit for helping to broker the ceasefire between Hamas and Israel in Gaza (Quinnipiac University 2025). Similarly, the end of the shutdown was favorable to Trump, as Republicans in Congress and, in part, Trump himself were being primarily blamed by the public for the extended closing of government offices, programs, and services (Navigator Research 2025).

We also isolate three events generally considered unfavorable to Trump: the release of additional, embarrassing documents regarding Trump's association with Jeffrey Epstein by the House Oversight Committee on November 12th, the demolition of the East Wing of the White House on October 20th, and the November elections on November 4th. Only 23% of U.S. adults approved of the East Wing demolition. In the off-cycle elections, Democrats won governor races in Virginia and New Jersey. Moreover, the election of democratic socialist Zohran Mamdani as mayor in New York was largely viewed as a rebuke to President Trump, who had threatened to withhold federal funding if Mamdani was elected (YouGov 2025).

We find relevant webpages for each of these events using string matching on webpages' html `title`

tags. For instance, we deem a webpage to be relevant to the release of additional Epstein documents if the parsed url title contains the string "trump" and "epstein". A webpage is relevant for the Gaza ceasefire if it contains "trump" and either "gaza," "palestine," "israel," "netanyahu," or "ceasefire"—while pages concern the East Wing demolition if they contain "trump" and either "demolish." "east wing," or "white house."

We then test whether following a favorable event, supporters of the president are more likely to visit webpages about each event and, inversely, whether unfavorable events lead opponents of the president to also seek out additional information. Equation 1 outlines our approach:

$$visit_{i,p,t,e} = post_t \times opponent_p + post_t + opponent_p + \Lambda_i + event_e + \epsilon_{i,p,t,e} \quad (1)$$

Our outcome variable is *visit* to webpages relevant to event e visited by individual i in the time period t before or after the event occurred. We operationalize *visit* in two different ways. First, we dichotomize visits by whether the individual visited at least one relevant webpage in the period. Second, filtering to only those individuals who visited at least one webpage, we use the count of the number of relevant sites visited. This dual approach lets us test for effects along both the extensive and intensive margins of news consumption. That is, whether favorable events, for example, both lead more supporters of the president to seek out online information about him and lead to additional news consumption among those supporters already consuming information about Trump.

We also measure *opponent* in two different ways using both partisanship (i.e., Democrat versus Republican) and ideology (i.e., liberal versus conservative). The key variable of interest is the coefficient on the interaction between *opponent* and the post-event time indicator. This captures the difference in post-event webpage visits across supporters versus opponents of President Trump. We include main effects for both time and partisanship/ideology (denoted p). Finally, we include fixed effects for each event e to control for baseline differences in attention and a number of individual-level controls (Λ_i), including respondents' age, race, sex, reported earnings, ethnicity, and education.[5]

We estimate the model separately for favorable and unfavorable events and use both logistic and negative binomial regression, depending on the operationalization of the dependent variable. We also run the models using different windows of time surrounding the events: +/- 1 day, 3 days, and 5 days. This helps account for variation in the length of news cycles and the durability of our results.

5. Besides age, all control variables are binary: whether a respondent is white, is male, reports earnings above the national median, is Hispanic, and did not attend college.

Figure 2 – Suggestive Evidence Partisanship and Ideology Moderate Probability of Searching for Information. Each blue point (and corresponding 95% confidence interval) shows the difference between the estimated difference in the predicted probability of clicking on a relevant link pre/post an event for Democrats versus Republicans. The orange dots display the same comparison but instead show the difference in pre/post differences for liberals and conservatives. Figure A.1 contains the actual pre/post changes in the predicted probabilities for searching by partisanship and ideology. Predicted probabilities estimated from a logit model with robust standard errors and controls for respondents age, race, sex, salary, ethnicity, education, and overall search activity. We run the model separately for good and bad events and include event-level fixed effects.

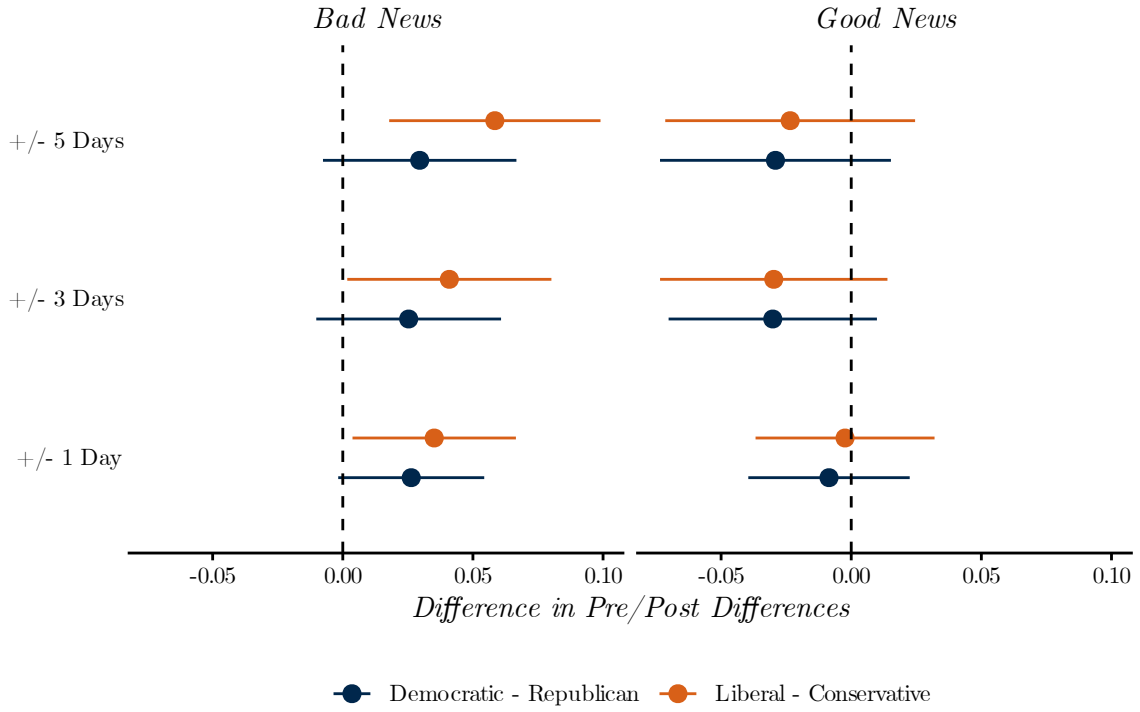


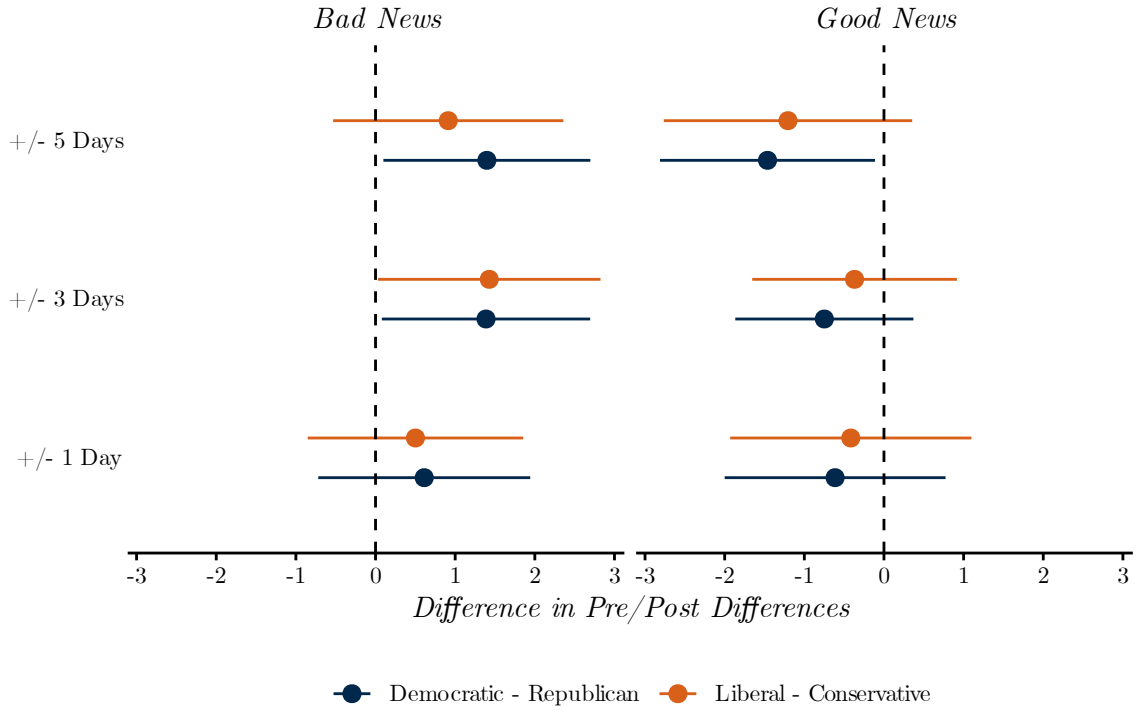
Figure 2 shows our results. We first test whether Trump supporters are more (less) likely to click on at least one webpage about the president in the days following a good (bad) event (i.e., the extensive margin). The blue points show the average difference between Democrats and Republicans in the predicted probability of clicking on a webpage regarding President Trump after versus before an event. The orange dots show similar information but instead compare self-reported conservatives and liberals. Estimates to the right of the dashed line suggest that Democrats (liberals) are more likely to click on a relevant webpage than Republicans (conservatives). Each coefficient is estimated from a separate logit model using different time windows (+/- 1 day, +/- 3 days, or +/- 5 days) and different types of news events (good or bad for President Trump).

Overall, the results paint a consistent picture. On average, after an event occurs that largely paints

Trump in a negative light, Democrats (liberals) are more likely to click on at least one webpage regarding the event than Republicans (conservatives). Liberals' increased propensity to click on webpages regarding an event is statistically significant, but the differences across both partisanship and ideology are signed as expected and substantively meaningful. The baseline probability of clicking on at least one webpage regarding a bad event within the 1, 3, and 5 day windows is, respectively, 0.05, 0.09, and 0.11. Thus, relative to these baselines, opponents of president Trump are, on average across partisan/ideology comparisons and time windows, approximately 47% more likely to click on a relevant webpage after a bad event. As expected, the results flip when the news instead paints Trump in a positive light. In this case—shown in the right-hand column of Figure 2—Republicans (conservatives) are more likely to click on a webpage regarding the event. While the estimates are not as precisely estimated, they are all signed correctly and, as with the estimated differences, substantively large.

Figure 3 shows similar findings, but instead of displaying partisan and ideological differences in the probability of searching for at least one webpage, displays differences in the number of webpages clicked on among those who visited at least one relevant webpage. The findings are consistent with those in Figure 2. When the news is bad for the president, Republicans (conservatives) are less likely to consume it than Democrats (liberals). When the news is instead positive, the results flip. Again, while not all estimates reach statistical significance, they are substantively large. For instance, among those who clicked on at least one relevant webpage in the period of time +/- 3 days surrounding a bad event for Trump, the mean number of visited webpages was 3.4. The mean number of webpages visited in the same time window surrounding a good event was 2.1. As with the results along the extensive margin, our results here suggest that, among those already tuned into the goings-on of the president, events that affect the president's image spur changes in online news behavior.

Figure 3 – Suggestive Evidence Partisanship and Ideology Moderate Probability of Clicking on Additional Information. Each blue point (and corresponding 95% confidence interval) shows the difference between the estimated difference in the number of relevant links clicked on pre/post an event for Democrats versus Republicans. Estimates are conditional on the person clicking on at least one relevant link. Orange dots and confidence intervals display the same comparisons but across ideological groups rather than partisan identities. Figure A.2 contains the actual pre/post changes in the number of links clicked on. Estimates derived from negative binomial models, estimated separately for good and bad events, with robust standard errors and controls for respondents age, race, sex, salary, ethnicity, education, and overall search activity. We include event-level fixed effects.



Views on Presidential Power as a Moderator

Thus far, we have shown evidence in presidential news that is consistent with known, stylized facts about news consumption. Namely, that there is both limited and differential take-up across the ruling and opposition parties. However, as Reeves and Rogowski (2022) show, Americans also hold views about presidential power that are distinct from their partisan identification or policy views. If these underlying beliefs impact consumption behavior, it is particularly relevant for the public check on unilateral action. For example, it might be that only the subset of Republicans with strong views in opposition to presidential power are more likely to consume bad news related to President Trump. This would imply that the differences in Figures 2 and 3 are driven by underlying differences in beliefs about presidential power across the parties.

We investigate this possibility with two measures of preferences about presidential power. Respondents were asked two batteries of questions regarding their views toward the president, executive power, and expansive unilateral actions. We were particularly interested in public views toward entrusting the government with broader executive power to act in the name of the public interest, even when it can interfere with individuals' rights to property, speech, and protest. Specifically, the first battery asked respondents, on a 5-point Likert scale, whether:

1. Government is better when one person makes the decisions
2. Leaders should have to get the approval of other branches of government before acting
3. The government should be able to take away someone's land or property when it decides that is necessary
4. The government should be able to punish people who say things that it decides are a threat
5. The government should be able to break up peaceful protests it decides are a threat.

In this way, our measure can be thought of a measure of general tolerance for illiberal authoritarianism. We specifically avoided referencing President Trump, or even the presidency itself.

A second battery focused more specifically on presidential power, asking respondents for their views on whether specifically presidents should circumvent other actors to achieve their own policy goals. The second battery asked participants, also on a 5-point Likert scale, whether:

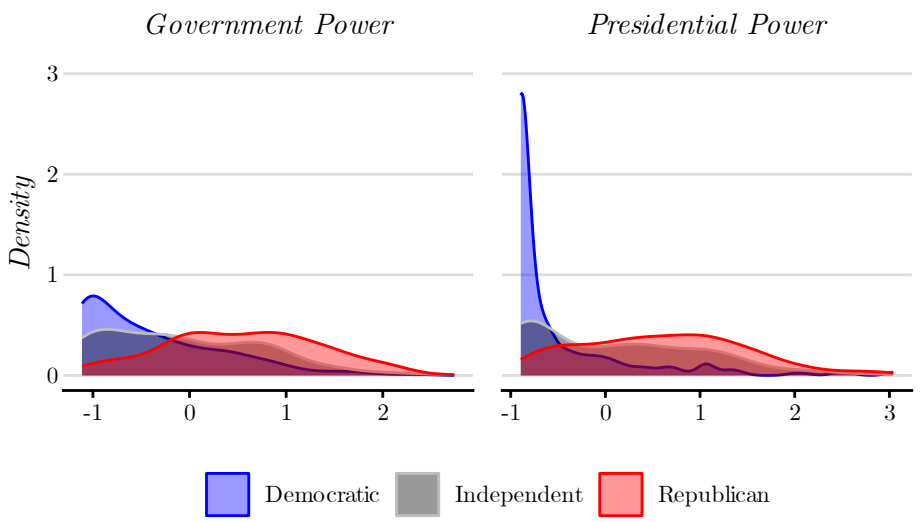
1. The President should set aside the advice of experts, when that is the only way to get what they promised done.
2. The President should set aside laws passed by Congress, when that is the only way to get what they promised done.
3. If Congress does not pass a law funding the government, the President should be able to spend money however they want.
4. The President should set aside the U.S. Constitution, when that is the only way to get what they promised done.
5. The President should set aside the decisions of judges, when that is the only way to get what they promised done.

We create composite scores from each measure using single-factor factor analyses. Both measures load well on a single dimension with Cronbach's Alpha values of 0.71 and 0.88, respectively. The loadings on the individual questions also suggest that each question is adding some unique information to

the score.[6] Figure 4 shows the distribution of the two measures by respondent partisanship.

As anticipated, the first measure, that does not prime respondents with "president" shows a greater similarity across partisan identities. In contrast, the second measure, which specifically picks up on views toward presidential power shows considerable differences. While many Republicans are fairly supportive of a more expansive and powerful U.S. president, Democrats are extremely unsupportive of entrusting more power in the president.

Figure 4 – Republicans Support Greater Governmental, and Especially Presidential, Power. Shows the density of the two measures of executive and presidential power by respondent partisanship.



We test whether, within party, views toward the exercising of presidential and governmental power further influence news consumption online. The methodological setup is largely similar to that used above. Focusing on the period immediately before and after events that paint Trump in a positive or negative light, we test whether, relative to their co-partisans, 1) Republicans who are more supportive of executive power are more likely to visit a relevant webpage following a good event; and 2) Democrats who are less supportive of executive power are more likely to visit a relevant webpage following a bad event. We test these hypotheses using linear probability models with a pre/post event indicator, our presidential power measures, event fixed effects, and controls for individuals' age, race, sex, reported earnings, ethnicity, education, and overall online activity.

Table 1 shows the results using the executive (models 1-4) and presidential power (models 5-8) mea-

6. The loadings on the questions in the first measure are 0.64, 0.38, 0.36, 0.73, and 0.75. The loadings on the second are 0.78, 0.83, 0.68, 0.67, 0.88, and 0.65.

Table 1 – Some Evidence That Views Toward Presidential Power Moderate News Consumption. Displays the results of eight linear probability models that test whether respondents' views toward presidential power moderate their probability of clicking on a relevant link after an event. Models are run separately by respondents' partisanship and event valence. P values estimated using robust standard errors.

	Rep.		Dem.		Rep.		Dem.	
	Good	Bad	Good	Bad	Good	Bad	Good	Bad
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Post	0.02	0.13^{***}	0.01	0.13^{***}	0.02	0.11^{***}	0.02	0.11^{***}
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.01)
Executive Power	-0.02	-0.00	-0.02	-0.02^{*}				
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)				
Post*Executive Power	0.03	-0.00	0.01	-0.06^{***}				
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)				
Pres. Power					0.02	0.02^{*}	-0.03^{**}	-0.01
					(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Post*Pres. Power					0.03	0.02	0.02	-0.07^{***}
					(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)
Baseline Prob.	0.11	0.10	0.08	0.12	0.11	0.10	0.08	0.12
N Obs.	1059	1544	1392	2043	1055	1538	1392	2043
N Respondents	310	305	408	402	309	304	408	402
Individual Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Event FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

$^{***}p < 0.001$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{*}p < 0.05$

sures by respondents' partisanship and whether the events are good or bad for Trump. The results are mixed. On the one hand, we show large and statistically significant differences within Democrats in terms of their online news consumption patterns depending on their views toward presidential power. Across both measures, Democrats who are less supportive of presidential power are even more likely to visit relevant webpages following a bad event for Trump, relative to their co-partisan peers.

The results are largely similar, although not statistically significant for Republicans who support a stronger executive after good news for Trump. This group is even more likely to visit relevant webpages after the event compared to Republicans who are more skeptical of executive power, across both measures. However, the results become weaker or inconsistent among Republicans after bad news for Trump and Democrats after good news. Among both of these groups, there is little consistent evidence of views toward presidential power moderating online news consumption.

Importantly, these results should be interpreted descriptively, as we cannot distinguish between different reasons views on presidential power might be associated with consumption among some partisans. Since our survey was fielded *after* the data collection period for web-browsing, it could be that views on presidential power were motivated by new information related to the events themselves. The same point can be applied to partisan identification.

Discussion

Despite President Trump's many unpopular unilateral actions, his overall popularity remains steady. Literature suggests the public should constrain the president from engaging in these actions, or that some public sanction should follow. To address this puzzle, we have argued that the public is both inattentive and biased in their uptake of presidential news. An inattentive public makes it difficult to recognize the president is overstepping in their authority. Selective partisan exposure strengthens partisans' preexisting beliefs about the president, undermining a public check that, by necessity, must be bipartisan.

Our study shows most people never search for news related to the president and, when they do, it is motivated by their partisanship and ideology. Moreover, differential consumption patterns are, in part, moderated by partisans' views toward presidential power. Of course, scholars have demonstrated that people are disinterested in politics. But we show that this behavior extends to news related to the president, notably over a period of repeated and escalating controversy. An important caveat, of course, is that these central tendencies are not deterministic. Republicans still consumed negative news about president Trump, and Democrats consumed positive news. The differences between the parties are not driven by utter blindness toward disfavored news.

Notably, we only tracked web-browsing behavior, but news consumption might occur in a more impressionistic way, through social media feeds. We did not observe social media feeds, only evidence that respondents had visited web-based interfaces for them like `facebook.com` and `x.com`. Put differently, our study is one of a particular kind of engagement (i.e., "click through"), which demonstrates more interest and is downstream of exposure in social media feeds or news landing pages. It is possible, of course, that these micro-doses of information are enough to alter beliefs about the president. However, given the existing experimental evidence on feeds as a method of attitude change, we suspect even this kind of exposure would not be important enough to matter for the president (e.g., Guess et al. 2023a, 2023b; Nyhan et al. 2023)

What our data cannot speak to, however, is a time horizon longer than the six-week period in question. It is possible that more exposure, over a longer period, might aggregate up to detectable attitude changes. It is also possible that the relevant presidential events or executive actions differ so markedly from individual to individual, that attempts to pre-specify universally relevant political stories always produce coarse consumption patterns. This possibility, while worthwhile to investigate empirically,

would also modify the definition of the public check. The president would not be sanctioned for taking individual executive actions, and therefore, have far more freedom to act without fear of public backlash on any given day.

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Supplementary Information

Deaf Ears and Echo Chambers in Presidential News

Benjamin Goehring, Kenneth Lowande, and Mario Villegas

Additional Results **SI-2**

Additional Results

Figure A.1 – Change in Predicted Probability of Visiting a Relevant Site. Shows the change in the predicted probability of visiting a relevant site in the 5 days before versus after an event favorable or unfavorable to Trump, by respondent partisanship and ideology.

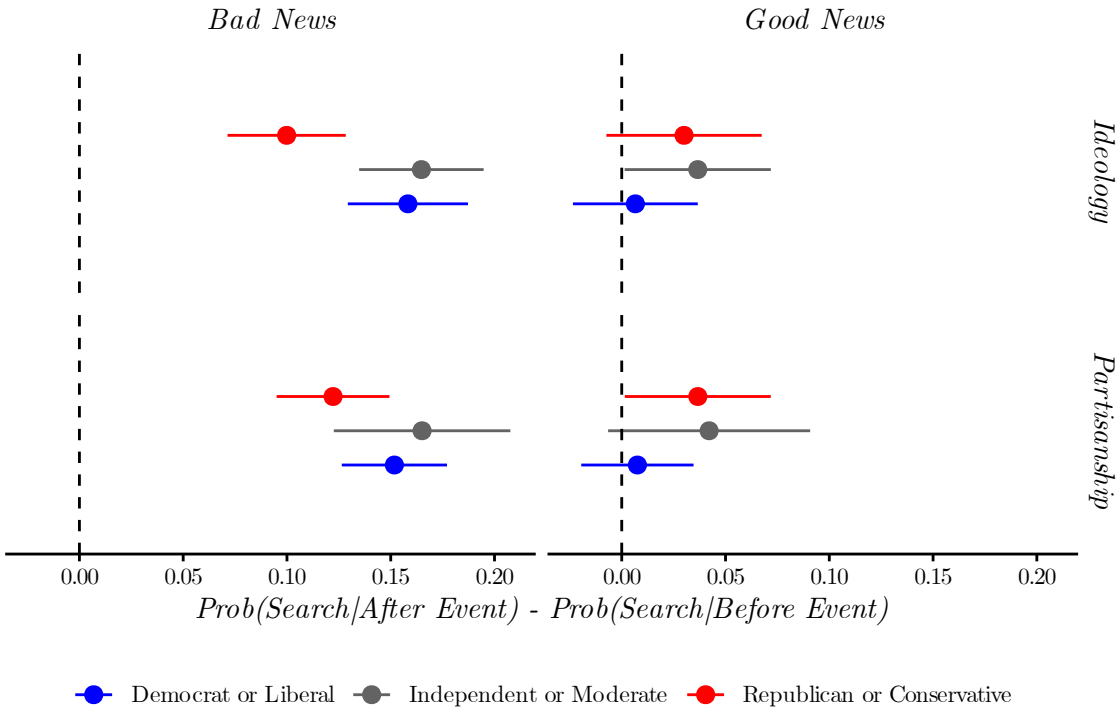


Figure A.2 – Change in Predicted Number of Relevant Sites Visited, Among Those who Visited at Least One Site. Shows the change in the number of webpages visited in the 5 days before versus after an event good or bad for Trump, conditional on visiting at least one webpage, by respondent partisanship and ideology.

